Magic function	Description	Example
%alias	Creates an IPython short-cut for a shell command.	*%alias l ls -lh (Now l is an alias for ls -lh.* Simply run 'l' from here on.*)*
%unalias	Removes an existing alias.	*%unalias l*
%bookmark	Bookmarks the path. Bookmarks are saved even across IPython sessions.	*%bookmark test /home/ankur/Desktop* The '-l' option displays a bookmarks list.
%dhist	Shows the directories you have visited.	*%dhist*
%hist	Shows command history.	*%hist* Magic commands will be encoded with *_ip.magic syntax.*
%who	Lists Python variables.	*%who*
%whos	Shows extra information about Python variables.	*%whos*
%upgrade	Upgrades your IPython installation.	*%upgrade*
%run	Is used to run an external file in the shell.	*%run filename.ipy*
%cd	Changes the working directory.	*%cd directoryname*
%magic	Provides an overview of magic functions.	*%magic*

class, description, usage, etc, as you can see in Figure 4.

Running external files

Sooner or later, you will want to run large Python scripts; with IPython, you can run files with the '.ipy' extension, in one of two ways:

- From the shell (Bash, usually), invoke IPython, passing the script file name as a parameter. For example, *ipython dateTest.ipy* (here, *dateTest.ipy* is a simple script with a *for* loop, which displays the system date 10 times).
- From inside an IPython interactive shell, use the *%run* magic function—for example, *%run dateTest.ipy* achieves the same result.

There's a lot, lot more to IPython

What I have described in this article is a very small part of IPython. Its power is incredible. It is the only interactive Python shell with built-in compatibility with Qt, WxWidgets and GTK—

Figure 1: Starting IPython

Figure 2: IPython with shell commands

Figure 3: A list of magic functions

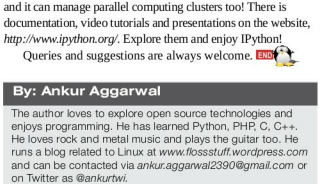

Figure 4: Output of %alias ?

and it can manage parallel computing clusters too! There is documentation, video tutorials and presentations on the website, *http://www.ipython.org/*. Explore them and enjoy IPython!

Queries and suggestions are always welcome. END

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